PEOPLE & CULTURE • REJECTION DECISION

Hackathon 2026

Hi Ali,

Dear Ali,

Thank you for spending your time with us and engaging so openly in our conversation. We genuinely appreciated the thoughtfulness you brought to our discussion, and we want you to know that your effort and openness mattered to us.

After careful reflection, we've decided not to move forward with your application at this time. We want to be clear about that upfront, because clarity is important. But then we'd like to share what we actually observed about youâ€”because we believe it's valuable feedback as you continue growing your career, and it deserves to be specific rather than generic.

What we genuinely saw in you

You have a real gift for thinking about technical problems holistically. When you talked about building a cricket prediction system, you showed us something important: you understand how different pieces fit together. You weren't just thinking about which model to use or where to get data. You were thinking about architectureâ€”how data sources connect to models, how models feed into dashboards, how users will actually interact with the system. You were thinking about tradeoffs: real-time versus batch processing, accuracy versus speed, what's achievable in the time you have.

That kind of systems-level thinking is genuinely mature. It's something many engineers take years to develop. You're showing it naturally, and that's a strength.

We also noticed your curiosity and flexibility throughout our conversation. You were willing to explore ideas, ask clarifying questions when something wasn't clear, and adjust your thinking as we talked. That openness to learningâ€”that comfort with not knowing something and being willing to figure it outâ€—is something that will serve you incredibly well in your career. That's the mindset that helps engineers grow.

Beyond the technical side, you showed real awareness of the human element. You talked about user experience, about how people would use what you're building, about styling and layout and interaction. You also showed honest thinking about constraints. You acknowledged that balancing what you want to build with what you actually have time to deliver is hard. That kind of realistic assessment of scope and resources is something we genuinely value.

Where you're still building

Right now, you're in a phase where you're exploring ideas and using available tools to help you build things. That's completely natural and healthy at your stage in your career. There's nothing wrong with it. But as you move forward, there's an important shift we'd encourage you to make.

When you're working on a project, we'd encourage you to spend time going deeper into the actual implementation. Pick one problem that genuinely excites youâ€”whether it's that cricket prediction system or something else entirelyâ€”and give yourself permission to really understand it. Not just the architecture or the high-level design, but how it actually works. Build it yourself. Debug it when things break. Fix problems when they don't work the way you expected. That direct, hands-on experienceâ€”the struggle, the problem-solving, the "oh, I see how that actually works" momentsâ€”that's where real confidence comes from.

Right now, you might feel like you understand something, but there's a difference between understanding a concept and understanding it so deeply that you can build it independently, troubleshoot it, and explain it to someone else. That depth is what transforms understanding into genuine capability.

What we'd suggest as your next steps

Here's what we'd encourage: Choose one problem that genuinely excites youâ€”something you actually want to understand, not just something you think you should build. Give yourself a few months to work on it. Build it. Make mistakes. Debug them. Learn from the process.

As you build, pay attention to what's hard. When something doesn't work, sit with it. Figure out why. That process of struggle and understanding is invaluable. It's also where you'll discover what you actually enjoy doingâ€”and that clarity about what engages you is really important.

Along the way, be honest about what you've learned and what you've struggled with. In future conversations with interviewers and with your teammates, that honesty is far more valuable than sounding confident about things you're uncertain about. People respect when someone says "I worked through this problem and here's what I learned" or "I'm not sure about that yet, but here's how I'd approach figuring it out." That clarity about your own knowledge is a strength.

Looking forward

You're early in your career. You have real potential. You think about problems in a thoughtful way. You're willing to learn. You're honest about constraints. Those are the qualities that make good engineers. Keep building on that foundation.

The next phase is about depth. Pick a direction. Go deep. Let yourself struggle and learn. That's where your real growth will happen.

We believe in your potential. Keep going.

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Hackathon 2026

Hi Umair,

Dear Umair,

Thank you for taking the time to talk with us and share your experience so openly. We really appreciated your thoughtfulness throughout our conversation, and we want you to know that your effort mattered.

We've decided not to move forward with your application at this time. We want to be direct about that because you deserve clarity. But I also want to share what we actually observed about you, because we think it's genuinely valuable feedback as you think about your next steps.

What impressed us about you

You have a solid technical foundation, and we mean that genuinely. You graduated in January 2026 and immediately moved into building a real product for a startup. That's not small. You went from university to working on a live web applicationâ€”that took courage and capability. The fact that you've continued building projects since then, working on freelance applications, shows something important: you can ship work. You understand what it takes to take an idea and turn it into something that actually functions and gets used.

What really stood out to us was your approach to problem-solving. During our conversation, you told us about a hackathon where you needed to generate text but the standard APIs you tried weren't working. You didn't give up. You researched alternatives, found Groq API, and solved the problem. That resourcefulnessâ€”that ability to hit a wall, think creatively, and find a way through itâ€”that's something every strong engineer needs. And you clearly have it.

Your coding task performance also showed us something real. You were given a character-counting problem and solved it efficiently using a hash map. That wasn't luck or following a pattern. That was understanding data structures and knowing when to apply them. You wrote clean code. You thought through the approach. That kind of technical execution is genuine, and it matters.

Where you're still building

Here's what we also observed: Right now, your expertise and your passion are clearly in backend development. Laravel, PHP, databasesâ€”you have real knowledge there. You've built things. You understand how these systems work. And that strength is genuinely valuable. It's something to be proud of.

But this particular role needed someone equally comfortable and confident across the full stackâ€”someone who could move fluidly between backend and frontend, who could think about both halves equally. Your frontend skills are still developing, and here's the honest truth: that's completely okay. You're early in your career. You have time to build those skills.

What we noticed was that when we talked about the frontend side of thingsâ€"React, component architecture, styling, user interactionâ€"your energy shifted. You became less engaged. And when you were talking about backend work, the expertise and the enthusiasm came through. That difference was really telling.

This isn't a criticism. It's actually valuable self-knowledge. It suggests something important: you might genuinely prefer backend development, and that's not a weakness. It's clarity about what engages you.

Where you could go

The question isn't whether you *can* learn frontend skills or become full-stack. You absolutely can. You have the foundation, the discipline, and the problem-solving ability. The real question is whether you *want* to do that right nowâ€"or whether there's a different path that might be more aligned with what actually excites you.

If backend development is what genuinely interests you, that's a strong path forward. Go deeper there. Build more ambitious backend projects. Get better at optimization, at database design, at system architecture. Become an expert in your domain. That expertise is incredibly valuable, and there are many opportunities for engineers who go deep in backend development.

If you do genuinely want to become full-stackâ€"if you see that as the direction that excites youâ€"then commit to it intentionally. Don't just add frontend skills on top of your backend work. Spend real time learning how React actually works, how CSS layout works, how JavaScript functions. Build a few substantial projects where you own the entire stackâ€"both sides. That direct experience is what transforms "I know about" into "I can do."

What we'd suggest

Take some time to think about which direction genuinely excites you. Not which is more impressive or what you think you should do, but what actually engages you. What problems do you enjoy solving? What kind of work makes you want to come back the next day?

Once you know thatâ€"whether it's deeper backend work or full-stack developmentâ€"commit to that direction. Build projects. Get experience. Become someone who can speak with confidence about that work.

Looking forward

Your foundation is solid. You've proven you can build real things and ship them. You have excellent problem-solving instincts. You're disciplined and thoughtful. Those qualities will take you far in your career.

The next phase is about choosing a direction and going deeper. That's how you build real expertise and real confidence. And we believe you can absolutely do that.

Keep building. You have real potential.

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Hackathon 2026

Hi Sultan,

Dear Sultan,

Thank you for coming and spending time with us. We appreciated your openness and willingness to engage with us in our conversation, even when things felt uncertain or challenging. That matters.

We've decided not to move forward with your application at this time. We want to be clear about that because you deserve directness. But I also want to share what we actually observed in you, because we think there's genuinely valuable feedback hereâ€"and we want to be encouraging about your potential.

What we valued in you

You have genuine curiosity about how technology works, and that's a real strength. The breadth of your experienceâ€"teaching STEM, working as a Python instructor, interning in computer vision, exploring generative AIâ€"that shows something important. You're not satisfied with one narrow path. You want to understand different areas. You want to try different things. That willingness to explore, that comfort with learning new domains, that's the foundation of becoming a good engineer.

You also showed real awareness of how technology actually works in the real world. When you talked about your plant health estimation project using YOLOv8 and Raspberry Pi, you showed us that you're thinking practically. You understand that just because a model works on a computer doesn't mean it works on edge devices. You know that models need to be converted to lightweight formats. That kind of practical thinkingâ€"understanding that deployment matters, that real-world constraints matterâ€"that's something that separates people who think about technology from people who understand how it actually gets built.

You demonstrated persistence and willingness to engage even when things felt difficult. You stayed in the conversation. You attempted to answer questions even when you weren't confident. You didn't shut down. That's a real quality. Growth comes from being willing to engage with challenge, and you showed that.

Where you're at right now

Here's what we also observed: You're at the beginning of your journey, and that's completely okay. But right now, you're exploring a lot of different areas. You're learning about computer vision, about generative AI, about full-stack development, about different frameworks and tools. That breadth is valuableâ€”it gives you exposure and helps you understand what's possible.

But here's the thing about being early in your career: you're also at a point where going deep in one area would actually be more valuable than continuing to explore broadly. Right now, you're like someone standing at a fork in the road, looking at five different paths. Each one is interesting. Each one has potential. But you haven't committed to walking down any one of them yet.

To truly grow and build real expertise, you need to choose. Not foreverâ€”just for the next year or so. Pick one area that genuinely excites you. Not the one you think you "should" do. Not the one that sounds most impressive. The one that actually engages you when you think about it.

Where that choice leads

Let's say you choose computer vision. Then spend real time understanding how YOLOv8 works. Not just using it, but understanding it. Read papers. Try different approaches. Build several projects. Know your project resultsâ€”exact accuracy numbers, what worked, what didn't, why. Reach out to companies doing similar work. Learn from them.

Or let's say you choose backend development. Then go deep on databases and APIs. Understand relational databases at a fundamental level. Understand HTTP and REST. Understand how to design systems that scale. Build several substantial backend projects.

Or machine learningâ€”then understand the math. Understand how algorithms work, not just how to call them. Understand Big O notation and why it matters. Understand when to use different approaches.

The point is the same for any path: pick one, commit to understanding it deeply, and invest your time and energy there for a year or two. That's how you move from "I've explored this" to "I know how to do this."

What we'd encourage

Ask yourself: What problem do I actually want to solve? What kind of work makes me curious? What do I want to understand deeply? Once you know that, commit to learning it properlyâ€”not just the tools, but the fundamentals underneath.

That depth is what will make you confident. That's what will make you valuable in a job. That's what will help you grow from an early-career person into someone with real expertise.

The fact that you've explored multiple areas is actually goodâ€”it means you have some sense of what's out there. Now it's time to pick a direction and go deep.

Looking forward

You're early in your career. You have curiosity. You have the willingness to try new things and learn. You have persistence. Those are the qualities that strong engineers are built on.

The next phase is about focus. Pick a direction. Go deep. Let yourself become genuinely competent in one area. That's where your real growth and confidence will come from.

We believe you can absolutely do that. Keep going.